

Bringing the war home

Gardner and O'Sullivan, who together made the "harvest of death" pictures on the sodden, corpse-strewn fields of Gettysburg, and Thomas Roche, who photographed the Rebel dead littering the Petersburg trenches, fed the public's increasing demand for realistic images of the war. While photographs printed as wood engravings were appearing more often in the popular magazines, stereo cards were also being eagerly snapped up.

With one eye on their commercial potential, photographers in the field used stereoscopic cameras that produced parallel negatives. Mounted on cardboard, the resulting albumen prints could be viewed through a stereoscope, providing a good simulation of three-dimensional reality. Marketed through the E. & H. T. Anthony Co. of New York, these stereo cards were the principal means by which the visual horrors of the war were seen in American parlors. Though the images offered only the briefest glimpses of the carnage, this did not lessen their impact on people who had never seen anything like it before—the dead on the fields of Antietam and Gettysburg and the corpses in the muddy trenches at Spotsylvania and Petersburg.

And no one was the wiser if photographers occasionally manipulated a battlefield scene by laying a rifle across a dead soldier for added drama. The images would have an enduring impact on the history of photography. Alongside the portraits of Abraham Lincoln, Robert E. Lee, and other prominent figures in the struggle, the images of the slain would achieve a hallowed status in American memory.